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THE STRAIN OF COMMAND

I WON'T name him, but one of the seniors in the team at the time – a great batsman in his own right – was majorly responsible for the breakdown of stability and goodwill within the Pakistan team. It saddens me to write this because he was one of the finest batsmen in those years.

A couple of months after the World T20, during the ICC Champions Trophy in South Africa in September 2009, this batsman essentially attempted a coup: he called a team meeting of the major players sans the captain, Younis Khan (Ijaz Butt was the PCB chairman and I was vice-captain at the time). In this 'midnight conference', he claimed to speak for all players when he announced that he was not satisfied and motivated under Younis Khan's captaincy. That was that – he had declared an all-out rebellion, bang in the middle of a major tournament.

To be sure, in those days, there were occasions when Younis used to mess things up for himself and everyone else by losing his temper. I don't mean to stereotype, but he is a fellow Pashtun, after all, and is prone to flare-ups. Aggression is part of our leadership style. Still, that didn't call for a full-blown rebellion against a very well-qualified captain and one of the game's finest batsmen. But that's exactly what the dissident batsman tried to do and – rightly or wrongly – he had enough followers to disrupt our performance. Personally, I felt he was overreacting and the idea of a rebellion was a bit extreme.

When the dissident told me his plan to marshal the players and inform Ijaz Butt that nobody wanted to play under Younis – all this in the middle of a tournament – I tried to convince him otherwise. First, I said that it was unfair of him to lobby other players into feeling as dissatisfied as him, especially the younger players. Second, I advised him to take the matter directly to Younis Khan and tell him, man to man, what his concerns were. I even offered to broker peace between them. The dissident refused. Moreover, Shoaib Malik (the former captain), Naved-ul-Hasan and Saeed Ajmal also endorsed his plan. He had a lot of firepower behind him.

I felt isolated. As vice-captain, with the Champions Trophy going on, I wanted the matter to be resolved and not to implode further. So I consulted Yawar Saeed, the team manager, and